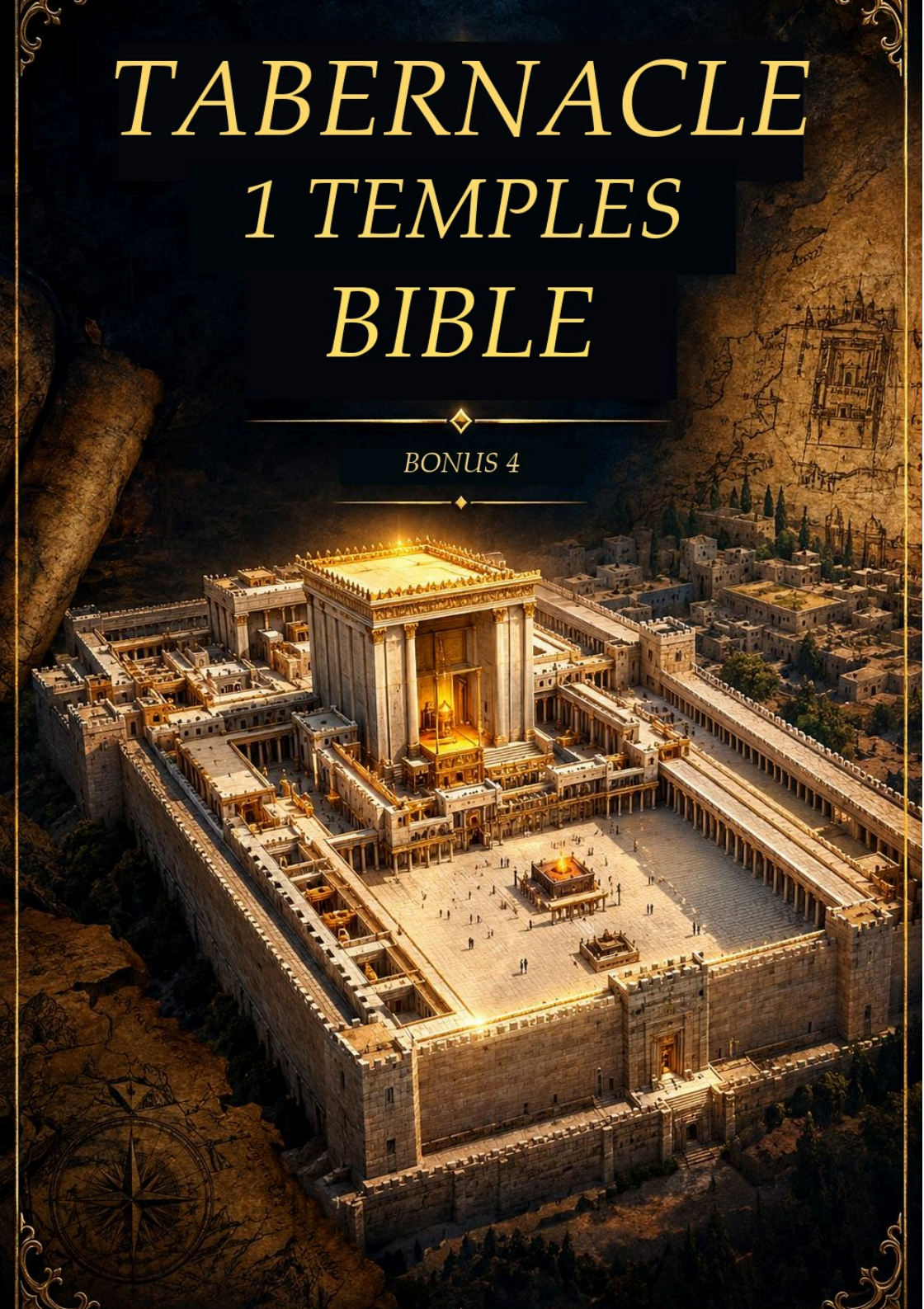
TABERNACLE 1 TEMPLES BIBLE

BONUS 4



BONUS 4

Tabernacle & Temples of the Bible 3D™

From a tent in the desert to Herod's great building: a guide to the places where Israel met its God.

For over a thousand years, the center of the biblical world was one place: the house of God among His people. First it was a portable tent pitched in the desert, then a stone building on a hill in Jerusalem, rebuilt and expanded after one catastrophe after another. Imagine walking through each gate in turn: through the courtyard, through the first room, all the way to the dark chamber that only one man could enter, once a year.

In this bonus we will recreate those spaces step by step. You will explore the layout of the Tabernacle from the Book of Exodus, Solomon's Temple, the more modest Temple of Zerubbabel, and Herod's impressive structure, along with the city, the priests, and the pilgrims. All dimensions are approximate and marked "c." We assume by convention that a cubit is about 0.5 m. The views and plans are artistic reconstructions based on biblical texts and archaeological research, not photographs of exactly what existed.

01

The Tent of Meeting: The Idea of the Tabernacle

C. 15TH–13TH CENTURY BC, SINAI DESERT



The Book of Exodus describes the Tabernacle as the place where God dwells among a people wandering in the desert. The instructions for building it fill many chapters (Exod 25–31), and its construction is described again (Exod 35–40), which shows how much importance was placed on detail. The whole people brought gifts for the work, and craftsmen such as Bezalel and Oholiab made the furniture, the fabrics, and the costly metalwork.

The tent had to be light and easy to take apart, because the camp moved on from time to time. The walls were frames of acacia wood, covered with curtains of fabric and skins. The whole stood in a rectangular courtyard fenced with linen, its entrance facing east. This layout, from the gate to the innermost chamber, set the pattern for all later temples. In the desert it could be set up in a few hours, and in Israel's tradition it remained the model for centuries.

- The Book of Exodus devotes many chapters to the Tabernacle, more than to many narrative events.
- The structure of acacia wood and fabric was portable.
- The entrance always faced east.
- The whole tribe of Levi was responsible for taking it down and carrying it.

WHY A TENT AND NOT STONE?

A people on the move needed a sanctuary that traveled with them. The tent said that God's presence is not tied to one place but accompanies the nation. Only settling in Canaan and the growth of a kingdom brought the idea of a permanent house. Yet the memory of the journey remained an important thread throughout the whole biblical tradition.

02

The Tabernacle Courtyard: Altar and Basin

C. 15TH–13TH CENTURY BC

The Tabernacle courtyard was a rectangle about 100 by 50 cubits, or about 50 by 25 m. It was surrounded by linen curtains held up by posts on bronze bases (Exod 27). Just inside the gate stood the altar of burnt offering, made of acacia wood overlaid with bronze, with a base of about 5 by 5 cubits and a height of about 3 cubits, or about 2.5 by 2.5 m and 1.5 m high. Here animal sacrifices were offered according to the rules of the Book of Leviticus.

Farther on, between the altar and the tent, stood a bronze basin of water for washing (Exod 30; 38). The priests washed their hands and feet in it before performing their service. The layout of the courtyard led the eye and the steps in one direction: from sacrifice, through cleansing, toward the entrance of the sanctuary. For an ordinary Israelite, the courtyard was the farthest place he could reach with an offering. The spaces beyond belonged to the priests.

- Courtyard: c. 100×50 cubits (c. 50×25 m).
- Altar of burnt offering: c. 5×5×3 cubits (c. 2.5×2.5×1.5 m).
- The basin of water stood between the altar and the tent.
- The altar had horns and portable poles.

THE CUBIT: A MEASURE FROM THE BODY

A cubit was the distance from the elbow to the tip of the middle finger, and in ancient times it varied from place to place. We use about 45–52 cm, which in our tables is set by convention at about 0.5 m. So every conversion to meters is an estimate and may be off by a few percent, especially for larger buildings.

03

The Holy Place: Table, Lampstand, and Altar of Incense

C. 15TH–13TH CENTURY BC



The first room of the tent, called the Holy Place, was about 20 cubits long and about 10 wide, or about 10 by 5 m. Inside stood three objects (Exod 25; 30). On one side was placed the table of the bread of the Presence, measuring about 2 by 1 cubit and about 1.5 cubits high, or about 1 by 0.5 m and 0.75 m high. The bread was replaced regularly, symbolizing the people's constant presence before God.

On the opposite side stood the golden lampstand, the menorah, with seven branches, shaped like a blossoming tree with cups and buds. The light of this lamp was the only source of illumination, since the tent had no windows. In front of the curtain that separated the innermost chamber stood a small altar of incense, on which fragrant spices were offered morning and evening. Only priests entered this space.

- Holy Place: c. 20×10 cubits (c. 10×5 m).

- Table of the bread of the Presence: c. 2×1×1.5 cubits.
- The menorah had seven branches and was made of gold.
- The altar of incense stood just in front of the curtain.

LIGHT WITHOUT A WINDOW

There were no windows in the tent, so the lampstand burned as the only light in the Holy Place. The priests made sure the lamps burned every day, and the oil was prepared from pure olives. In later centuries the menorah became one of the most recognizable symbols of Judaism, seen on coins, lamps, and in sculpture.

04

The Most Holy Place and the Ark of the Covenant

C. 15TH–13TH CENTURY BC

Behind a heavy curtain was the Most Holy Place, a cube-shaped room about 10 cubits on each side, or about 5 m. In it stood only the Ark of the Covenant, a chest of acacia wood overlaid with gold, measuring about 2.5 by 1.5 by 1.5 cubits, or about 1.25 by 0.75 by 0.75 m (Exod 25). On its lid, called the mercy seat, were two golden cherubim, and inside were kept the tablets of the covenant.

Only the high priest entered this chamber, and only once a year, on the Day of Atonement (Lev 16). He brought in incense and the blood of the sacrifice, asking for the people's cleansing. The rest of Israel could only know that the Ark was there, and look at the curtain as the boundary of holiness. When the people traveled, the Ark was carried on poles, and even the Levites were not allowed to touch it.

- Most Holy Place: c. 10×10×10 cubits (c. 5×5×5 m).
- Ark: c. 2.5×1.5×1.5 cubits (c. 1.25×0.75×0.75 m).
- The high priest entered there once a year.
- The Ark was carried on poles, not by hand.

WHAT HAPPENED TO THE ARK?

The Bible does not say exactly what happened to the Ark after the first Temple was destroyed. The account of the rebuilding after the exile does not mention it either. Tradition and scholarship offer many hypotheses, but none has firm confirmation. To be honest, its fate remains unknown.

05

Priests and Levites

C. 15TH CENTURY BC – 1ST CENTURY AD

Service at the sanctuary belonged to the tribe of Levi. From it came the priests, descendants of Aaron, and the Levites, who helped with the duties (Num 3–4; 1 Chr 23–26). The priests offered sacrifices, burned incense, and taught the people, while the high priest held the highest liturgical office. The high priest's garments are described in detail: the ephod, the breastpiece with twelve stones representing the tribes, and the turban with its plate (Exod 28).

The Levites handled the practical side of the service: they carried the sanctuary, guarded the gates, sang and played instruments, and in later times also served as teachers and treasurers. David divided the priests and Levites into shifts so that the service ran smoothly throughout the year (1 Chr 24). In New Testament times, priests served in the Temple in weekly rotations, then returned to their towns and villages.

- The priests descended from the house of Aaron, the Levites from the rest of the tribe of Levi.
- The high priest wore a breastpiece with twelve stones.
- David divided the service into shifts (1 Chr 24).
- The Levites were also singers, musicians, and gatekeepers.

TITHES AND SUPPORT

The Levites received no territory of their own in the Promised Land, but cities to live in and a share of the gifts the people brought. This allowed them to devote their time to service. The system of tithes and offerings funded both the sanctuary and the upkeep of those who worked in it. The specific rules and how they were applied changed over the following eras.

06

Solomon's Temple: The First House of Stone

C. 960–586 BC



Solomon built the first Temple on Mount Moriah, following the plan of his father David (1 Kgs 5–8; 2 Chr 2–7). The construction took about seven years. The materials, especially cedar, were brought from Lebanon through an agreement with Hiram of Tyre. The building was about 60 cubits long, 20 wide, and 30 high, or about 30 by 10 by 15 m. In front of the entrance stood a porch, and beside it two bronze pillars, called Jachin and Boaz.

The interior repeated the layout of the Tabernacle, but on a larger scale: the Holy Place was about 40 cubits long (c. 20 m), and the Most Holy Place about 20 by 20 cubits (c. 10 by 10 m). The walls were paneled with cedar and gold and decorated with carved cherubim and palm trees. In the Most Holy Place stood two large cherubim of olive wood, and the Ark was placed between them. Instead of a single lampstand, the Holy Place held ten.

- Building: c. 60×20×30 cubits (c. 30×10×15 m).

- Most Holy Place: c. 20×20 cubits (c. 10×10 m).
- Construction took about seven years, and the cedars were brought from Lebanon.
- The pillars Jachin and Boaz stood before the entrance.

NO EXCAVATIONS OF ITS OWN

No certain remains of Solomon's Temple itself have been found so far, because the site is occupied by later buildings and is closed to excavation. However, temples with a similar layout are known from other cities of the region. That is why all reconstructions rely mainly on the biblical description and are artistic in nature.

07

The Exile and Zerubbabel's Temple

586–516 BC

In 586 BC Babylonian armies destroyed Jerusalem along with the Temple and carried part of the population off to Babylon (2 Kgs 25). After about half a century, the Persian ruler Cyrus allowed the exiles to return. Under the leadership of Zerubbabel and the high priest Joshua, they began rebuilding the altar and then the foundations (Ezra 3). The work was interrupted by conflicts with the local inhabitants, and resumed at the urging of the prophets Haggai and Zechariah.

The Temple was dedicated around 516 BC (Ezra 6). It was more modest than the previous one, and the elders who remembered Solomon wept at the sight of it, though others rejoiced (Ezra 3). A document in the Book of Ezra gives the height and width as about 60 cubits (c. 30 m), but does not describe the layout exactly. What we know is that the Ark was no longer there, and the Most Holy Place remained empty.

- Destruction of the first Temple: 586 BC.
- Dedication of the second: c. 516 BC.
- A Persian document mentions a height and width of about 60 cubits.
- The Most Holy Place remained empty, without the Ark.

PROPHETS URGE THE WORK ON

The books of Haggai and Zechariah show how the prophets urged the returnees to finish the rebuilding when people preferred to build their own houses. The message was simple: do not put off the things of God. Both books give a glimpse into the hard daily life of a small, poor community that was rebuilding its religious life practically from scratch.

0 8

Herod's Temple: The Great Rebuilding

C. 20 BC – AD 64



Around 20 BC King Herod the Great began a thorough rebuilding of the Temple. The undertaking was so enormous that work was still going on in the time of Jesus (John 2). Herod enlarged the platform on which the building stood to about 480 by 300 m. This required massive retaining walls of huge stone blocks, a section of which, the Western Wall, stands to this day. The new building was made of light-colored stone and adorned with gold.

The sanctuary building itself, keeping the traditional layout, was taller: accounts speak of about 100 cubits (c. 50 m), though descriptions from Roman times do not fully agree. Herod must be judged in two ways: he was a cruel and suspicious ruler, and at the same time a great builder. The priests themselves did the work inside the sanctuary, because laymen were forbidden to enter. For that reason they were trained as builders.

- Start of the rebuilding: c. 20 BC.

- Temple platform: c. 480×300 m.
- Height of the sanctuary according to accounts: c. 100 cubits (c. 50 m).
- The Western Wall is today a remnant of the retaining wall.

THE STONES THAT REMAIN

Huge blocks in the lower parts of the retaining walls survive to this day, and archaeologists have also found the stairs leading to the entrances and fragments of the ancient gates. These are proof of a solid building plan. All the more striking are the words in the Gospel that not one stone of these impressive buildings would be left on another (Mark 13).

09

Herod's Courts: From Gentiles to Priests

1ST CENTURY BC – 1ST CENTURY AD



Herod's Temple grounds formed successive circles, each more restricted. The outermost was the Court of the Gentiles, open to everyone, including non-Jews. A low balustrade with inscriptions warned foreigners against going any farther. Here animals for sacrifice were sold and money was exchanged, which is the setting of the scene of the cleansing of the Temple (Mark 11; John 2).

Farther in lay the Court of the Women, open to Jews of both sexes, and beyond it the Court of Israel, where men could come near the altar. Next came the Court of the Priests with the great altar of burnt offering, and finally the sanctuary building itself with the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. According to the description in the Mishnah and in Josephus, this arrangement resembled a staircase going up, each step marking a higher level of holiness.

- The Court of the Gentiles was open to everyone.
- The Court of the Women served all Jews, including for bringing gifts.

- The Court of Israel was set apart for the men of Israel.
- The Court of the Priests surrounded the great altar of burnt offering.

WARNING INSCRIPTION

Stone tablets have been found with a Greek inscription forbidding foreigners to go past the balustrade on pain of death. Two such examples are known to archaeologists. They show that the boundaries of the sacred space were taken very seriously. It is worth remembering this when reading the passage in the Letter to the Ephesians about the breaking down of the dividing wall.

10

Jerusalem Around the Temple

C. 1000 BC – 1ST CENTURY AD



Jerusalem lay on hills surrounded by valleys: the Kidron on the east, and the Hinnom on the west and south. The City of David occupied the southern ridge, and Solomon moved the religious center north, to the Temple Mount. In Herod's time the city grew to include districts in the west, the royal palace, and the Antonia Fortress at the northwest corner of the Temple. Stairs and bridges across the Tyropoeon Valley led up to the platform.

Water was drawn at the Gihon Spring and the Pool of Siloam, and Hezekiah's Tunnel, carved through the rock, brought it to a safe place within the walls. The surrounding area also included the Mount of Olives, with its slopes covered in groves, and Gethsemane. The city lived from the Temple: it gave work to priests, craftsmen, merchants, and the hosts who received pilgrims. During the feasts the population grew considerably.

- The Kidron and Hinnom valleys surrounded the city on three sides.

- The Antonia Fortress adjoined the Temple platform.
- Hezekiah's Tunnel brought water to the Pool of Siloam.
- The Mount of Olives lies east of the Temple.

A CITY LIFTED UP

One always went up to Jerusalem. The Psalms of the pilgrims, called the Songs of Ascents, reflect this experience: travelers sang as they approached the city from every side. The difference in elevation captures well the meaning of the words about going up to the house of the Lord, used many times in the Bible.

11

The Pilgrim Feasts

EVERY YEAR

The Law of Moses commanded three great feasts at which adult men were to present themselves at the sanctuary: Passover, the Feast of Weeks (Pentecost), and the Feast of Tabernacles (Deut 16; Lev 23). Passover commemorated the exodus from Egypt, Pentecost the wheat harvest and the gift of the covenant, and the Feast of Tabernacles the time in the desert and the ingathering. On these occasions crowds poured into Jerusalem from all over Palestine and the diaspora.

In the 1st century AD so many pilgrims came that the houses were not enough, so they stayed in the surrounding villages. According to the Acts of the Apostles, on the day of Pentecost there were Jews from many countries in the city (Acts 2). The Day of Atonement also had special importance, the only day when the high priest entered the Most Holy Place. In the New Testament, this festival setting is the backdrop for many events in the life of Jesus.

- Three pilgrim feasts: Passover, Pentecost, Feast of Tabernacles.
- The Day of Atonement was tied to the high priest's entry into the Most Holy Place.
- Pilgrims came from Palestine, Egypt, Mesopotamia, and Rome.
- The Songs of Ascents were sung on the way to the city.

HOW MANY PILGRIMS WERE THERE?

Ancient sources give very large numbers of Passover participants in Jerusalem, but historians treat them with caution, because ancient authors tended to exaggerate. One thing is certain: during the feast the city became a crowded center where languages, clothing, and customs were all mixed together. An exact number cannot be given.

12

The Destruction in AD 70 and the Legacy

AD 66–70 AND LATER

In AD 66 a revolt against the Romans broke out. After several years of fighting, in AD 70, Titus's army took Jerusalem, and the Temple went up in flames, just as Jesus had foretold of its destruction (Mark 13). Many cult objects were carried off to Rome, and their image appears on the Arch of Titus, carved a few years later. The sacrificial service of the priests came to an end, because without the Temple it could not be carried out.

Judaism then went through a profound transformation: the synagogue, the study of the Torah, and prayer became its center. Christians, for their part, read the Temple as a foreshadowing of Christ and of the community of believers (John 2; 1 Cor 3; Heb 9; Rev 21). Today other buildings stand on the Temple Mount, and the Western Wall remains a place of prayer. The memory of the ancient sanctuary lives on in the liturgy and tradition of both religions.

- Destruction of the Temple: AD 70.
- The Arch of Titus in Rome depicts the menorah among the spoils.
- After AD 70 the priestly sacrifices ceased.
- The Western Wall remains a place of prayer.

THE TEMPLE IN THE NEW TESTAMENT

The New Testament also uses the image of the Temple in a figurative sense: Jesus speaks of the temple of His body, and Paul of the community of believers as the house of God. The Book of Revelation shows a city with no temple, because God's presence is everywhere in it. This closes the picture that began in the Book of Exodus.

SUMMARY

Overview Table

ELEMENT	TABERNACLE	SOLOMON'S TEMPLE	HEROD'S TEMPLE
Time (approx.)	c. 15th–13th century BC	c. 960–586 BC	c. 20 BC – AD 70
Place	Desert, mobile camp	Mount Moriah, Jerusalem	Expanded platform in Jerusalem
Courtyard / grounds	c. 100×50 cubits (c. 50×25 m)	Inner courtyard, dimensions incomplete in the Bible	Platform c. 480×300 m
Holy Place	c. 20×10 cubits (c. 10×5 m)	c. 40×20 cubits (c. 20×10 m)	Similar proportions, larger scale (c.)
Most Holy Place	c. 10×10×10 cubits (c. 5 m)	c. 20×20×20 cubits (c. 10 m)	c. 20×20 cubits, separated by a curtain
Building height	c. 10 cubits (c. 5 m)	c. 30 cubits (c. 15 m)	c. 100 cubits (c. 50 m) according to accounts
Altar of burnt offering	c. 5×5×3 cubits (c. 2.5×2.5×1.5 m)	c. 20×20×10 cubits (2 Chr 4)	c. 32×32 cubits according to the Mishnah (c. 16 m)
Lampstand	One menorah	Ten lampstands	One menorah
Ark of the Covenant	Present (c. 1.25×0.75×0.75 m)	Present	Absent, empty Most Holy Place

Table of bread	c. 2×1×1.5 cubits (c. 1×0.5×0.75 m)	Golden table(s)	One table
Materials	Acacia wood, gold, fabrics	Stone, cedar, gold	Light stone, gold
Access	Courtyard, tent: priests	Outer and inner courtyard	Five zones: Gentiles, women, Israel, priests, sanctuary

The Tabernacle and the Temples of Solomon, Zerubbabel, and Herod are four stages of one story, about a God who wants to dwell among people, and about people learning how to approach Him. The dimensions in this bonus are approximate and the reconstructions are artistic, but the layout is always the same: from the gate to the heart of holiness. The next time you read the Bible, try to find this path, step by step.